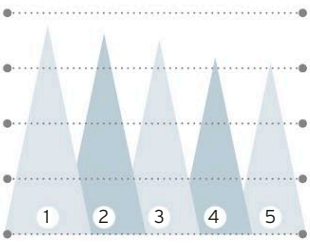


HIGHEST PEAKS IN THE SIERRA MADRE



- 1 Mt. San Rafael 12,238 ft (3,730 m)
- 2 Mt. El Potosí 12,205 ft (3,720 m)
- 3 Mt. El Nacimiento 12,172 ft (3,710 m)
- 4 Sierra de La Marta 12,156 ft (3,705 m)
- 5 Mt. Teotepéc 11,647 ft (3,550 m)

The Sierra Madre

A majestic system of mountain ranges extending diagonally across Mexico and forming a part of the North American Cordillera



Mexico's Sierra Madre has three main parts—the Sierra Madre Occidental (in northwest Mexico), the Sierra Madre Oriental (in the northeast), and the Sierra Madre del Sur (in the south). Between the Occidental and Oriental ranges lies the Mexican Plateau. This consists of layers of sedimentary rock, laid down in shallow seas 250–65 million years ago, that have subsequently been eroded into an angular, gouged landscape in the Sierra Madre Occidental and

a more rounded terrain in the Oriental. Parts of the range also show signs of past volcanism in the form of igneous rock intrusions and layers of hardened lava poured out by long-disappeared volcanoes.

Labyrinthine landscape

The western side of the Sierra Madre Occidental is a series of high escarpments (steep slopes that form due to faulting or erosion) whose sides drop into deep canyons called *barrancas*. The dimensions of some of these, notably the Copper Canyon, or Barrancas del Cobre, are comparable to those of the Grand Canyon (see pp.54–57) in the U.S.

The Sierra Madre Oriental is cut through by many steep-walled narrow valleys. Many of these are aligned in a north–south direction, but there are also several passages through these mountains that run from the lowlands of the Gulf of Mexico to the east. The Sierra Madre del Sur consists of a labyrinth of narrow ridges and steep-flanked valleys.

◁ GREAT DESCENT

A part of the Copper Canyon of the Sierra Madre Occidental, Urique Canyon is the deepest canyon in North America, descending 6,135 ft (1,870 m) from its highest point.



Popocatépetl

North America's second highest volcano and the second highest peak in Mexico, with a history of violent eruptions



Towering to a height of 18,491 ft (5,636 m), Popocatépetl, which means “smoking mountain” in the ancient Aztec language, is famous because of the ferocity of its eruptions, its tongue-twisting name, and its proximity to Greater Mexico City, the largest metropolitan area in the Americas.

Violent nature

A stratovolcano, Popocatépetl, or “El Popo,” can be seen erupting from most parts of Mexico City. Over the past few thousand years, it has had three Plinian eruptions—extremely violent blasts that produce huge plumes of gas and ash. Such explosions can cause large loss of life in populated areas. After a massive eruption in 1947, the volcano lay dormant until it came back to life in 1994. Ever since, smoke has been seen

emanating almost daily from its huge summit crater. The year 2000 saw the most dramatic eruption in more than a thousand years. In April 2016, it erupted again, spewing out lava, ash, and rock, and it has continued to produce powerful explosions at irregular intervals.

▽ HIGH CONE

Popocatépetl's height, symmetrical shape, and snow-covered summit give it an imposing presence.

